

TRUSTMRR DATASET

What 1,000 Startups Datasheet Says About the AI Long Tail

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15 insights across 5 themes · \$133.75M aggregate TTM revenue · 4 rated high-confidence

Analyst brief for investment review · Data frozen 30 July 2026 · Read slide 3 first

ORIENTATION

The dataset in five numbers

1,000

startups, 29 fields
self-listed on TrustMRR

\$133.7M

aggregate trailing-12-month
revenue across all listings

\$3,068

median TTM revenue
half are near pre-revenue

50.6%

of all revenue held
by just 10 startups

43.8%

of revenue sits in
uncategorised rows

READ THIS FIRST

This is a self-listed, Stripe-skewed sample. Founders opt in to display revenue, which selects for indie hackers proud of their numbers. Treat every finding as a read on the micro-SaaS long tail — not on the AI market. Venture-scale AI companies do not list here at all.

FIVE THEMES, FIFTEEN INSIGHTS

1

The AI label has stopped
carrying information

2

Monetisation design beats
category

3

Distribution assets track with
revenue

4

Momentum is negative, worse
inside AI

5

The dataset will mislead you
first

Median used throughout, never mean — the revenue distribution is a power law.

ORIENTATION

How to read this deck

EVERY INSIGHT CARD HAS FOUR PARTS

The bold headline	The finding, with its number stated inside it.
THE EVIDENCE	Which fields, which filter, and the sample size.
THIS COULD BE WRONG IF	The most plausible way the finding is an artifact.
WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT	The specific data that would settle the question.

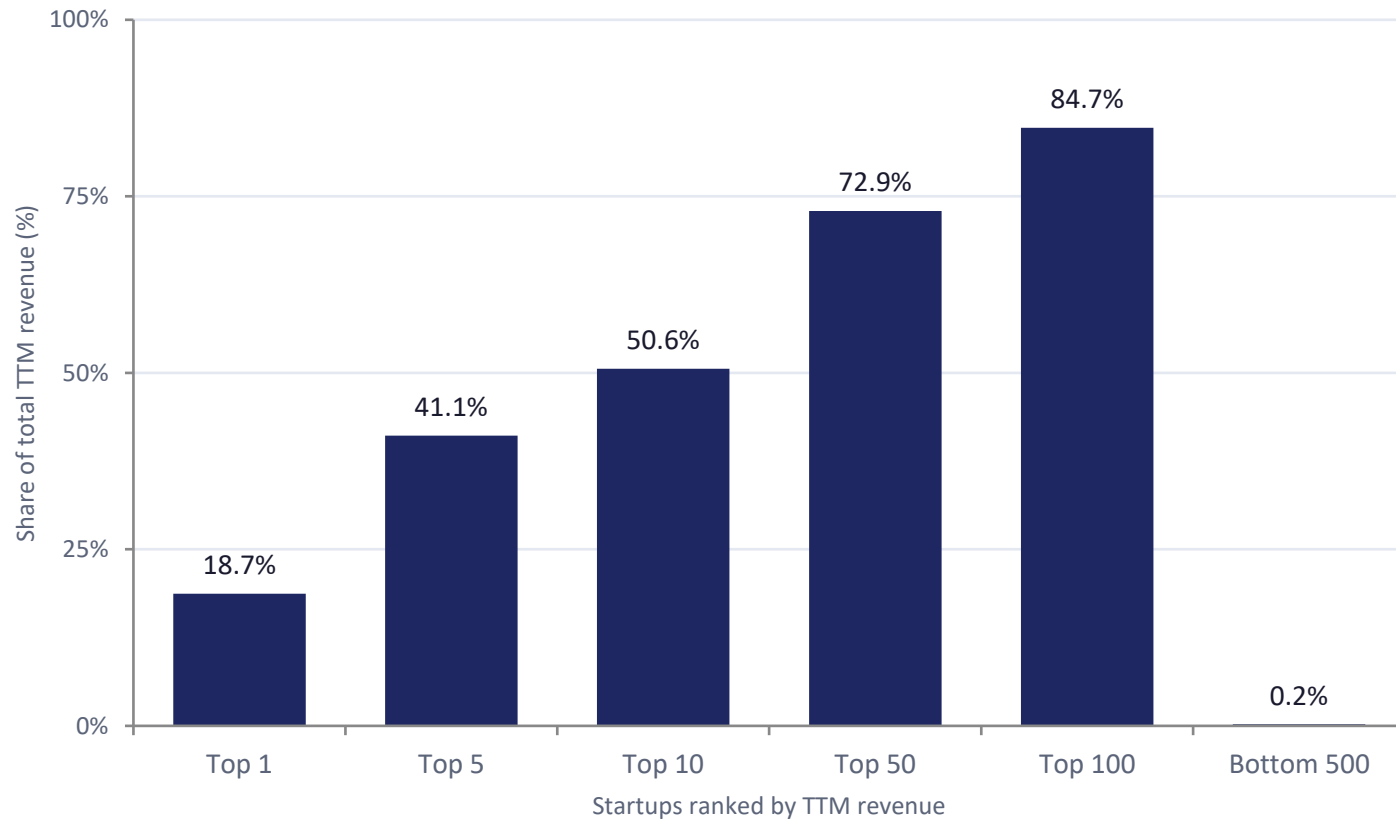
EACH CARD ALSO CARRIES A CONFIDENCE RATING

HIGH	Direct count or verified arithmetic. $n > 200$. Act on it.
MEDIUM	Sound sample, but causality or coverage unresolved.
LOW	$n < 60$, or a plausible data artifact. Verify before use.

METHOD AND DEFINITIONS

TTM	Trailing twelve months. Field: revenue_12m_usd.	Spearman	Rank correlation, 0 to 1. Measures whether two things move together, not by how much.
ARPU	Median monthly revenue per paying subscription ($\text{mrr_usd} \div \text{active_subscriptions}$).	Published multiple	TrustMRR computes $\text{asking_price} \div (\text{revenue_30d} \times 12)$. Verified to 0.027 median deviation, $n=217$. This deck recomputes on TTM revenue instead.
Median / p75	50th and 75th percentile. Means are never used — the distribution is a power law.	Nulls	Blank revenue treated as zero. 90 rows report revenue_3m = 0 alongside positive TTM; these are excluded from growth analysis.

Revenue is a brutal power law



Why it matters

- The bottom 500 startups together hold 0.21% of revenue.
- Stan alone accounts for 18.7% — one company, one fifth of the market.
- Any category average is really describing two or three companies.
- Report medians and name the concentration every time.

“AI” is now the default tag, not a category

1

AI tag covers 54% of labelled startups (392 of 726) — commoditised, not differentiating.

HIGH

THE EVIDENCE

Direct count of “AI” in the markets_json field, n=726 labelled rows

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

Tags are self-reported; the scraper may over-assign AI liberally

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

Founding dates, to test whether tagging is a recency artifact

2

AI median TTM revenue \$3,812 vs non-AI \$3,174 — a \$638 premium.

LOW

THE EVIDENCE

Median revenue_12m_usd, AI n=392 vs non-AI n=334

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

Both medians sit near zero; a \$638 gap is economically meaningless

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

Company age and funding stage, to control for cohort maturity

Takeaway: the AI label no longer separates winners from the field — it describes the field. Underwrite something else.

And the market is already pricing that in

3

AI holds just 15 of the top 50 revenue earners, despite being 54% of the population.

MEDIUM

THE EVIDENCE

Top 50 ranked by revenue_12m_usd; 15 carry the AI tag

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

274 uncategorised rows carry no tags at all and are excluded

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

Category inferred from website scrape for the stealth listings

4

Acquirers pay 3.3x TTM revenue for AI vs 3.8x for non-AI — a discount.

LOW

THE EVIDENCE

Median asking_price ÷ TTM revenue; AI n=57, non-AI n=63, TTM ≥ \$10k

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

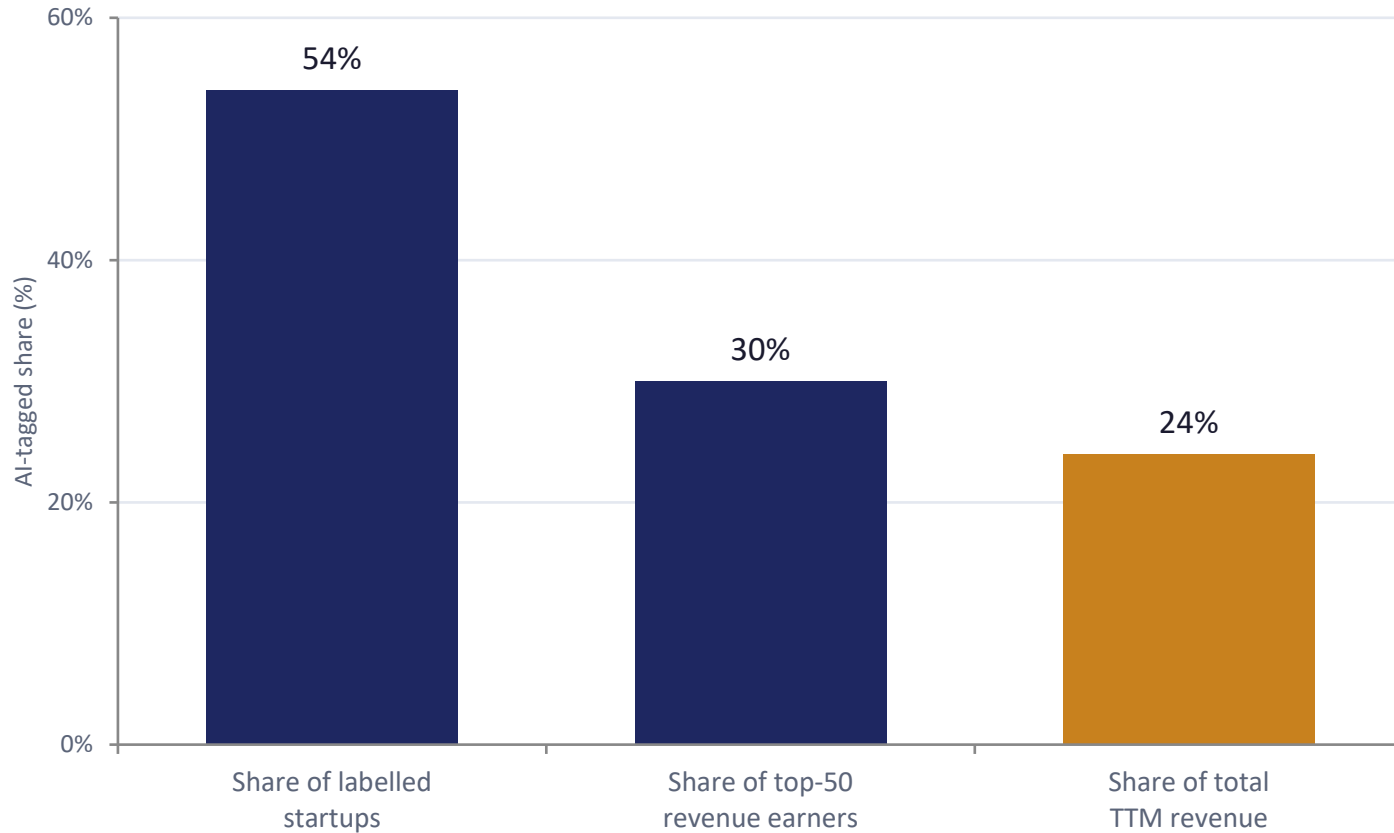
These are seller-set asking prices, not prices anything actually cleared at

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

Closed-transaction data from Acquire.com or Flippa

Takeaway: at this end of the market AI carries a valuation discount, not a premium — but on small samples of asking prices.

Half the population, a quarter of the revenue



The gap

AI-tagged companies are 54% of the labelled population but capture only 24% of the revenue.

If the AI label conferred real commercial advantage, those two bars would be level.

They are not close.

How you charge beats what you build

5

Sales-led pricing earns \$10,980 median TTM — 3.7x subscription pricing's \$2,989.

LOW

THE EVIDENCE

Median TTM by pricing pattern; sales-led n=20, subscription n=433

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

n=20 is tiny, and failed enterprise attempts never get listed at all

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

Whether traction precedes sales-led pricing, or follows from it

6

AI startups with a free tier earn \$1,576 median TTM vs \$7,191 for paid-only.

MEDIUM

THE EVIDENCE

Within AI-tagged rows, free/trial vs paid-only pricing_model strings

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

A free tier may signal an earlier-stage company, not a worse strategy

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

Free-to-paid conversion rates and company age per startup

Takeaway: pricing structure separates outcomes 3-4x more cleanly than vertical does. Diligence the pricing page first.

Audience and structure set the ceiling

7

B2B earns \$49 per subscriber per month vs B2C's \$9.34 — a 5.2x gap.

HIGH

THE EVIDENCE

Median monthly revenue per active subscription; B2B n=228, B2C n=330

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

B2C may compensate through volume — check totals, not just per-seat

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

Churn rates and contract length, to test whether the gap is durable

8

One-time pricing caps upside: 75th-percentile TTM \$4,778 vs subscription's \$26,978.

MEDIUM

THE EVIDENCE

p75 of TTM revenue; one-time n=85, subscription n=433

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

One-time pricing suits low-frequency tools by design, not by failure

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

Whether lifetime-deal revenue predates the 12-month window

Takeaway: B2B wins on revenue per startup despite being outnumbered 255 to 401. Recurring pricing raises the ceiling, not just retention.

Owned distribution is the real moat

9

Domain authority correlates 0.57 with revenue; X followers only 0.21.

MEDIUM

THE EVIDENCE

Rank correlation of domain_rating and x_followers against TTM revenue

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

Causality may run backwards — revenue funds SEO investment

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

Traffic-source split, to separate organic search from paid

10

Startups selling to sales teams earn \$20,194 median — 5x those selling to creators.

LOW

THE EVIDENCE

Sales/outbound persona n=16 vs creators/influencers n=106

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

At n=16, one outlier moves the median substantially

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

Whether the high revenue is software or disguised services

11

India: 59 startups at \$98 median TTM, against \$12,292 for the US.

LOW

THE EVIDENCE

Country-level medians; US n=258, India n=59

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

Indian founders likely use Razorpay, which this dataset does not scrape

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

Payment-provider coverage mapped by country before concluding anything

Active subscriptions correlate 0.81 with revenue — but that is near-tautological. Domain authority at 0.57 is the finding worth acting on.

The cohort is shrinking, not compounding

12

Half of revenue-generating AI startups shrank last month, against 40% of non-AI.

MEDIUM

THE EVIDENCE

Negative 30-day revenue growth among startups above \$10k TTM, n=387

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

One month is a snapshot; seasonality is entirely unmeasured here

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

A 6 to 12 month revenue series per company, not a single delta

13

Startups listed for sale shrink more: 40% negative growth vs 32% of unlisted.

MEDIUM

THE EVIDENCE

on_sale = true, n=262, against n=738 not listed

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

Founders may deliberately list on strength, timing an exit at peak

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

Tracking listings to resolution — sold, delisted, or left stale

Takeaway: assets offered for sale are decelerating faster than those that are not. Assume adverse selection until shown otherwise.

Two fields that will break your model

14

The published multiple annualises 30-day revenue; it ranks listings at only 0.59 vs TTM.

HIGH

THE EVIDENCE

Rank correlation 0.585, n=215. 47 listings display a false 0.0x multiple

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

TTM is also imperfect for genuinely fast-growing young companies

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

Monthly revenue series, to pick a defensible denominator

15

274 uncategorised startups hold 43.8% of all revenue — \$58.5M of \$133.75M.

HIGH

THE EVIDENCE

Rows with a blank category field; 115 are named Stealth or Hidden

THIS COULD BE WRONG IF

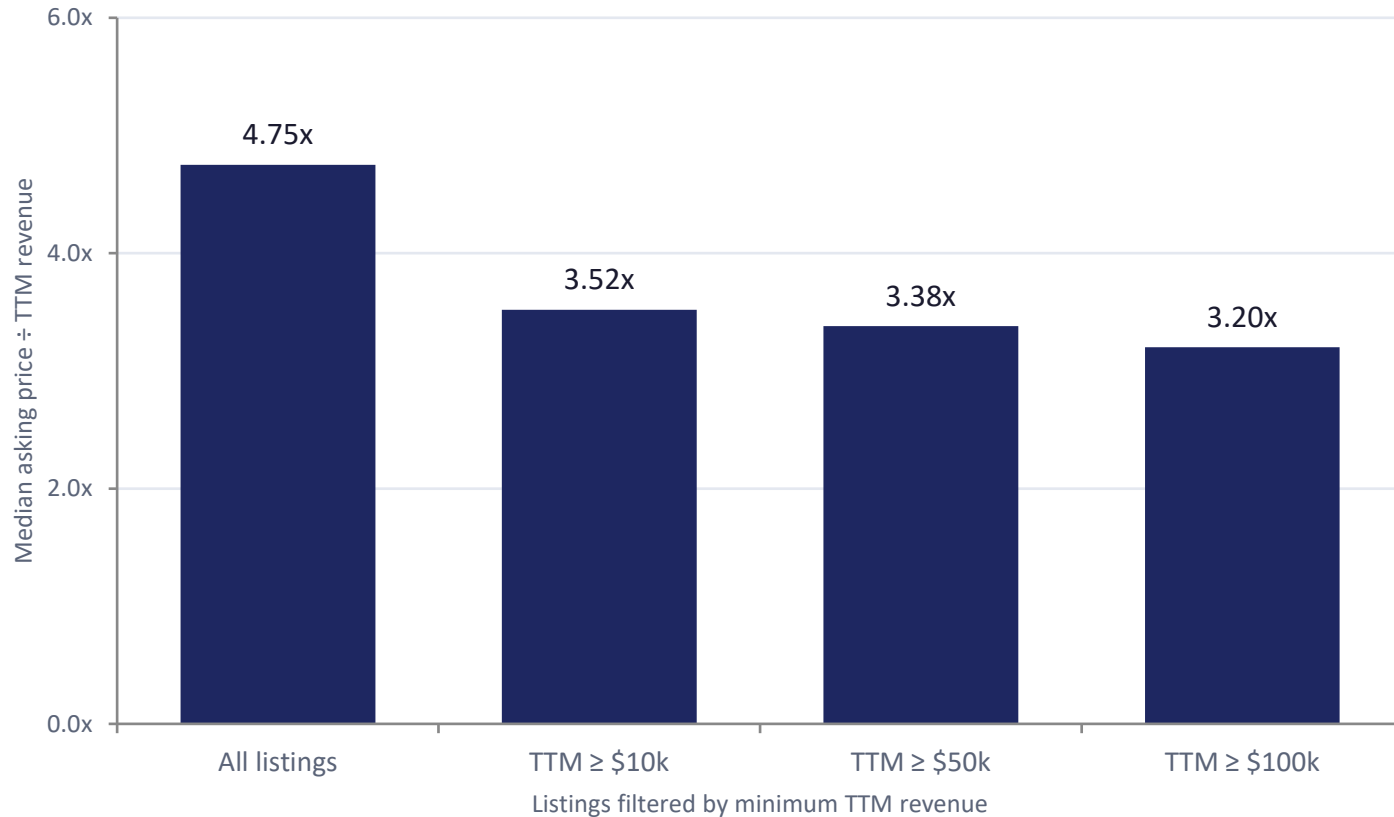
Nothing — but note these opt out deliberately, so cleaning will not fix it

WHAT WOULD CONFIRM IT

A benchmark against Stripe Atlas or Acquire.com for comparison

Takeaway: two fields — the published multiple and the category label — will silently corrupt any model built straight off this export.

Recomputed on TTM revenue, the real market rate is 3.2x



The published column understates

- Published data shows 28 listings above 10x. Recomputed on TTM, 69 are.
- Annualising 30 days assumes a startup's best month repeats twelve times.
- Worst case: one listing earned its entire \$9.98 lifetime revenue last month — published 5.8x, actual 70x.

Only 4 of 15 findings are ready to act on

HIGH

4 of 15

Act on these now

- 1 — AI tag covers 54% of the field
- 7 — B2B ARPU is 5.2x B2C
- 14 — Published multiple is broken
- 15 — 43.8% of revenue uncategorised

MEDIUM

6 of 15

Directionally sound, causality open

- 3 — AI is 15 of top-50 earners
- 6 — Free tier vs paid-only gap
- 8 — One-time pricing caps upside
- 9 — Domain authority correlates 0.57
- 12 — Half of AI startups shrank
- 13 — Listed startups shrink more

LOW

5 of 15

Verify before citing

- 2 — AI revenue premium is \$638
- 4 — AI trades at a discount
- 5 — Sales-led pricing earns 3.7x
- 10 — Sales-team persona earns 5x
- 11 — India median is \$98

Eleven of fifteen findings rest on samples under 60, unresolved causality, or a suspected coverage gap. That is normal for a scraped self-listed dataset — what is not normal is presenting them as if they were equal.

WHAT TO DO WITH THIS

Three conclusions, one caveat

1

Stop underwriting the AI label

It describes 54% of the field and captures 24% of the revenue. It predicts nothing.

2

Underwrite pricing structure instead

B2B per-subscriber revenue runs 5.2x B2C — the largest and best-evidenced gap in the dataset.

3

Recompute every published multiple

The listed figure ranks deals at 0.59 against TTM. Never compare two listings on it.

THE CAVEAT

Self-listed, Stripe-skewed sample. This reads the micro-SaaS long tail, not the AI market. Venture-scale companies do not list here.